snows, he warmed himself with a three-day feast during which he ate little, but drank a very great deal indeed. He slipped into a coma, emerging only long enough to declare that his grandson Pir Muhammad should inherit the throne of Samarkand.[12]

On February 18, 1405, the Iron Cripple died.

The empire he had conquered had no infrastructure, no real network of administration, no coherence, and no stability. Another grandson seized Samarkand; Pir Muhammad, attempting to get it back, was murdered by one of his own men in 1407. Timur's youngest son, Shah Rukh, had been serving him as a governor in the eastern part of the empire; he took it for himself. And the western reaches of the empire were quickly claimed by the Turks between the Caspian and the Black Seas.

The tribes there were linked together into two separate confederations, the Black Sheep ("Qara Qoyunlu") and White Sheep ("Aq Qoyunlu") Turkomans. They occupied adjacent and overlapping territories, the White Sheep just south of the Black Sea, the Black Sheep on the southwestern Caspian shore. The White Sheep took Mardin and the surrounding lands; the Black Sheep captured Tabriz in 1406 and Baghdad in 1410. Soon the Black Sheep halted the White Sheep expansion and overran the remnants of the kingdom of Georgia, killing the nominal king Constantine. Their chief, Qara Yusu, then worked out a truce with the mamluks of Egypt that would guarantee the existence of the Black Sheep as an independent kingdom—temporarily, the most powerful Turkish kingdom in the east.[13]

But only temporarily. The Timurid empire had shivered apart, but the Ottoman empire was busy righting itself. In June 1413, the civil war between Bayezid's heirs finally ended when his sixth son, Mehmed, defeated and then strangled his last surviving brother, Musa. Mehmed then declared himself both the undisputed sultan of the ravaged Ottoman realm and the loyal friend of Constantinople; the emperor Manuel had taken the strategically brilliant precaution of providing Mehmed with Byzantine warships and troops to help him fight against his brother. "Go say to my father the Emperor of the Romans that, with the help of God and the support of my father the Emperor, I have recovered my hereditary dominions," Mehmed wrote to the court of Constantinople, after his victory. "He will find me neither unheeding nor ungrateful."[14]

He kept his word. The Ottoman sultanate needed to rebuild in any case; defeat at the hands of Timur, followed by ten years of fraternal fighting, had wrecked it. He was in no shape to restart the war with Byzantium, even if he wanted to. Mehmed signed a treaty of peace with Manuel and went to work rebuilding his army, firming up his control over his Serbian lands, and